Creative Skill Development Plan

CIM301.1: Project 1

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1.0 - Industry Skills Research

There is a vast range of skills for an audio practitioner to acquire in different industries, including games, film, and music. Simple skills to maintain that benefit all audio-related subjects are contained within technical audio expertise. These include knowledge of sound physics, proficiency with audio-related equipment, a deep understanding of the DAW (Digital Audio Workstation) available to you, and mixing skills. Major skills such as Foley creation, Sound design, and studio engineering are all important to becoming a practitioner who will continue to be in demand and guarantee success in finding audio-related work. Sound design is a section that I would like to focus on in particular for this project, and Foley will likely be in line with achieving that outcome.

The future seems to see audio practitioners having the ability to focus more on the creative aspect of their careers with topics like AI, plugins such as Izotope's suite of plugins that enhance and repair audio through the process of machine learning, that complete tasks in hours that would usually take weeks, and VSTs such as Kontakt that have an almost infinite library of sounds capable of mimicking their corresponding instruments with ease, freeing up the budget aspect. However, there may be drawbacks in how audio practitioners are valued for their work and may be perceived as a role that will become less of a forefront when technology can mimic the practitioner's job.

Immersive and spatial audio technology is becoming a centerpiece for the future of audio. With 5.1 mixes being a core part of film sound design, *"Sound designers are now pivotal in crafting immersive environments in virtual and augmented realities" (Gereb, 2024),* the idea that this system will branch out to other industries leads me to believe that the sound design process will become even more intricate and in-depth, using panning, position, and other variables to create an immersive 5.1 soundscape in music with Apple's implementation of Dolby Atmos within iTunes, video game sound engines adopting 3D spatialised implementations, animation, and live sound with the use of D&B soundscape in live venues.

2.0 - Industry Skills Gap Analysis (SWOT Analysis)

SWOT Analysis

Strengths	Weaknesses
-Strong signal flow knowledge within both analog and digital. -Understanding of effects and mixing process. -Strong understanding of DAWs. -Experience in many sectors of audio. Film, Games, Music, Animation, Live Sound. Pre and Post-production. -Good managment of files within projects and understanding of timeline to complete tasks. -Confidence in my knowledge to complete tasks that are new to me through simple research and current skills.	-While I can communicate well for projects, I feel that connecting with project partners or clients can be difficult. -Lacking knowledge in fields that are beneficial. E.g. Mastering, sound design. -No work experience. -Procrastination habits. -low budget. -Lack of music theory knowledge for audio in music to have any input on the creative aspect. -Tend to become more of a solo act instead of trying to work with peers.
Opportunities	**Threats**
-Emerging audio skills and demands to grasp. -Future projects and capstone to upskill and develop a proffesional level project to showcase. -Portfolio expansion and cleanup -Work experience -Young age to branch and develop skills early.	-AI machine learning and the competition between who would you rather with a budget. -The re-evaluation of an audio practitioners value with technologies and equipment that may make a job too easy for the money involved. -The rise of digital and influx of audio participants from home.

My strengths come from a deep understanding of digital technology before joining SAE, using multiple DAWs and software to upskill my knowledge of audio solely in the digital realm. However, I found that I became limited to the digital realm and wanted to explore analog gear and techniques that were otherwise not possible when contained digitally. This thought process is how I became interested in SAE and found that my skills expanded with the use of simple hardware like microphones and mixing desks. This is also where my knowledge of signal flow became much more adept and my confidence to learn through simple research became efficient.

Constantly using the studios for many of the projects along the journey became an interest to me, and any new gear that I found in the studios was always a pleasure to get to know. The knowledge of all this hardware is vital to moving forward in the industry as many audio technicians find what gear works for them and what doesn't. With one piece of hardware, some technicians may find it extremely useful to them while others may very much dislike having to use them at any point in their process. It can be the same for artists who find a microphone that pushes their voice to the next level and stick with it for the rest of their careers. For me, it's finding the right piece of hardware and learning its ins and outs before applying that knowledge to my workflow. *"Like with so many things on this list, it comes down to your needs and goals." (Benediktsson, N/A)* Benediktsson explains here that there is a vast amount of options for all types of equipment that audio engineers need. However, the equipment should be tailored to your workflow, needs, and goals. This is the deliberate way of how I would move forward with my equipment.

My weaknesses usually consist of a lack of experience in the industry which is really why I am attending SAE to gain the knowledge required to participate in the world of audio and transition to the working field afterwards and that is a primary fear of mine as of late. *Henke* puts it best when she says that I should *"Accept that everything is going to change"* and see *"change as an opportunity for personal growth and learning, instead of a negative thing" (N/D).* Moving onto the workforce from study is daunting to me but I am willing to accept that change will be a positive in this situation. While I have made close friends here working on projects, it can take time to become friendly with clients or project partners who are not consistently putting in the same effort or are difficult to rely on.

Some areas are yet to be covered in my experience in audio. Either they were very quickly talked about or not at all. For me, that is mastering, sound design, and maybe more if I were to give it more thought, but these seem to stick out to me as important.

I also have a bad habit of procrastination, however, that has not been as bad since starting at SAE.

I have never been late for any project deadlines and can manage and complete tasks before the deadline.

Other weaknesses include a very low budget to work with outside of what is available at SAE as a student living out of home and a lack of music theory knowledge in audio where music can be a core part of the work. However, I find that music theory isn't completely necessary in completing tasks related to audio in music.

Moving on to opportunities that I can see available to me at this stage, there are many skills and demands available to grasp at such a young age that can take time to master. I've made it clear previously that grasping the use of hardware and software as a sound engineer is crucial to improving your workflow and efficiency. With capstone around the corner, I also have a chance to completely flesh out a portfolio with the path of a freelancer.

Threats to my progression in the audio industry may come down to the advancement of technology and how the value of an audio technician can be decreased with how easily the technology can complete a task in place of an audio technician. The rise of home sound engineers with the rise of digital audio may also prove a barrier to an oversaturated market, and therefore I may be forced to target a niche. AI may fall under the advancement of technology and how consumers may lean towards the use of AI instead of audio practitioners to have work completed for them.

3.0 - Project Portfolio Vision

Specific - Build A library of Foley and SFX through field recording and sound design. Master the equipment that is required for the process of creating a library. Learn sound design techniques to create unique and exciting sounds.
The final product should come in the form of a sound pack like what you would see for certain genres of music, however, this will be a certain theme for Foley. At the moment I am leading to a more gore-like and violent theme for the Foley recordings, including sounds such as bones breaking, hits, impacts, and blood spurts, with more ideas to come. The sound pack will be displayed on a mock-up site with consideration to be put up for online retail in the future if it is to a quality I find acceptable.
Measurable - Set a plan to fill categories of a library and how these sounds will come to exist. Recording process. Audio Editing. Mixing and sound design. Fill up the library—the amount of sounds. Checklist of equipment and knowledge about said equipment. Sound design techniques to incorporate into my workflow. Even create pre-sets. The pack should contain around 100 sounds with upwards of 5 categories containing between 15 to 25 sounds each.
Achievable - The equipment available on campus is more than enough to achieve these goals. Some of the process can also be completed while away from campus. Many articles and tutorials online can help with both learning equipment techniques and sound design. 6 weeks is more than enough to split the different activities into weekly sections to easily clear the deadlines for this project.
Relevant - This goal can become of greater use in future projects as experience and also having assets available for my personal use. This goal can also achieve profits over time if a library is used for sales. Equipment knowledge will always prove useful when approaching job opportunities and sound design is a handy tool for all aspects of audio.
Time-bound - This goal can be achieved in a designated timeline if planned and executed well. Put together a week-to-week goal chart of how the project should flow and be completed with spare time. The Project is to be completed within 6 weeks with the schedule planned out to be completed within 5 to allow for spare time. [It has to be finished by week 12]

Evaluated - Every session dedicated to this project will be reflected upon in terms of performance and quality, both personally and in assessing the work. Feedback will also be received by my mentor and peers in our weekly mentor sessions.
Revised - Feedback is needed to improve and set the project goals that align with those of the LOs. Expectations will be adjusted to meet these criteria.

4.0 - Project Plan

4.1 - Deliberate Practice Plan

- **How the sessions are going to be goal-oriented**

  Find and set a theme for this project. Planning out categories of sounds and how they will be captured. Set a goal of about 100 sounds altogether. Recording process and the amount of sessions required for the different categories of sounds. Recording techniques for each category. Find and research how these sounds are commonly captured and apply these techniques to capture these sounds. Cut and polish all sounds into manageable chunks and sessions to be edited. Use sound design processes and techniques to create a more unique set of sounds. Apply some sound design techniques to create even more unique sounds or just apply a clean-up overall to the sounds I have captured. Sort these sounds into their respective categories and create a library. Create a mock-up online website for the sound pack to be put up for sale as the final product.

- **How you will be incorporating repetition into the sessions**

  Multiple recording sessions and sound design sessions to up-skill myself in those areas. The amount of sessions depends on the workload and how efficient I become in these areas. If Foley sounds are not up to my standards, repeat the recording process until I am satisfied with their quality or apply post techniques to polish the sounds or create new ones.

- **How you will seek and receive feedback**

  Peer feedback is always something I prioritise as I like to get a viewpoint from the perspective of someone else also going through the learning process and how they would go about a goal or project. Mentor feedback is also always appreciated as experience is always important in defining how I should approach a goal. This feedback will always be taken seriously and incorporated into the project goals and work. I will get and log the project feedback in our weekly mentor sessions.

- **How you will ensure that each session is challenging**

  The techniques used to create certain kinds of sounds like celery sticks for bones and books for impacts and punches are something I want to research well before giving it a try to hopefully have the outcome be as good as possible. With a variety of different sounds in this theme, I will have to research how these sounds are created, captured, arranged, and processed. Blood spurts are completely unknown territory and I will have to explore how the creation of this type of Foley is created.

- **How you will incorporate reflection into the practice**

  My view on this matter is that with experience comes the knowledge to complete the task more efficiently and that doing the task over and over again will help improve my overall proficiency in a subject which is the creation and capturing of these sounds. Each session will have me remembering how I went about the process and how I will improve on the next so that the overall product will be better and the process will be faster.

4.2 - Project Schedule/Gantt Chart

PROJECT SCHEDULE

DATE : 28TH OCTOBER 2024 START **CLIENT :** [redacted]

WEEK 1

HAVE THEME AND CATEGORIES OF SOUNDS PLANNED OUT AND BE READY WITH RESEARCH TO RECORD AND CAPTURE SOUNDS IN THE FUTURE WEEKS.

WEEK 2

RECORD AND CAPTURE PLANNED OUT CATEGORIES OF SOUNDS. WHILE I MAY NOT HAVE ALL SOUNDS RECORDED I MAY STILL FIND THAT CLEANING AND POLISHING THE SOUNDS WOULD HELP FILL OUT THE REST OF THE WEEK.

WEEK 3

REPEAT THE PROCESS OF WEEK 2 AND IMPROVE ON THE PROCESS THAT IS RECORDING AND CAPTURING.

WEEK 4

IF THERE ARE MORE CATEGORIES TO COVER AND RECORD THEN COMPLETE AND FINISH THE RECORDING PROCESS WHILE ALSO FINISHING UP THE CLEANUP AND POSSIBLE SOUND DESIGN PROCESS.

WEEK 5

FINISH POLISH AND CATEGORY ORGANISING. CREATE A MOCK UP WEBSITE FOR THE SOUND PACK TO BE ADVERTISED AND SOLD ON. FINISH ANY PROJECT DOCUMENTATION AND HAVE WEEK 6 BE A WEEK TO FINISH ANYTHING THAT IS NOT YET COMPLETED THROUGHOUT THE COURSE OF THIS PROJECT.

4.3 - List of Potential Learning Materials (readings, tutorials, videos, lessons)

Skills Needed To Be An Audio Engineer | Expert Tips
(Practical Music Production)
Showcases the essential skills needed in the audio industry as an audio engineer. Explores key takeaways of audio engineers and covers them in detail.

Top Skills for Audio Engineers in 2024 (+Most Underrated Skills)
(Teal HQ)
Covers basic and niche skills that are a priority in the sound industry.

The Future of Audio Engineering: Trends and Innovations in the Industry.
(In The Know, 2023)
Covers current evolving audio techniques that are bound to enhance the audio industry and how to approach them.

Emerging Trends in Sound Design for 2024
(Gereb, 2024)
Covers new platforms for creative expression in sound design techniques that are evolving the audio industry in new ways.

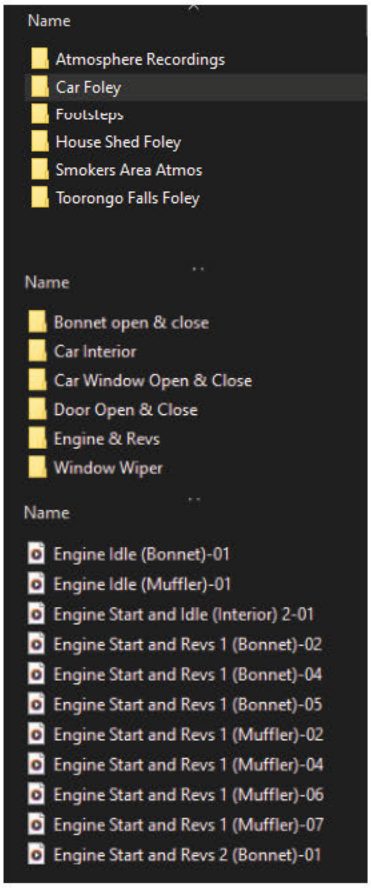
The Biggest Challenges Facing Audio Engineers Today
(Espinoza, 2023)
A quick video dive into how the rise of digital technology is a challenge and saviour for audio engineers today.

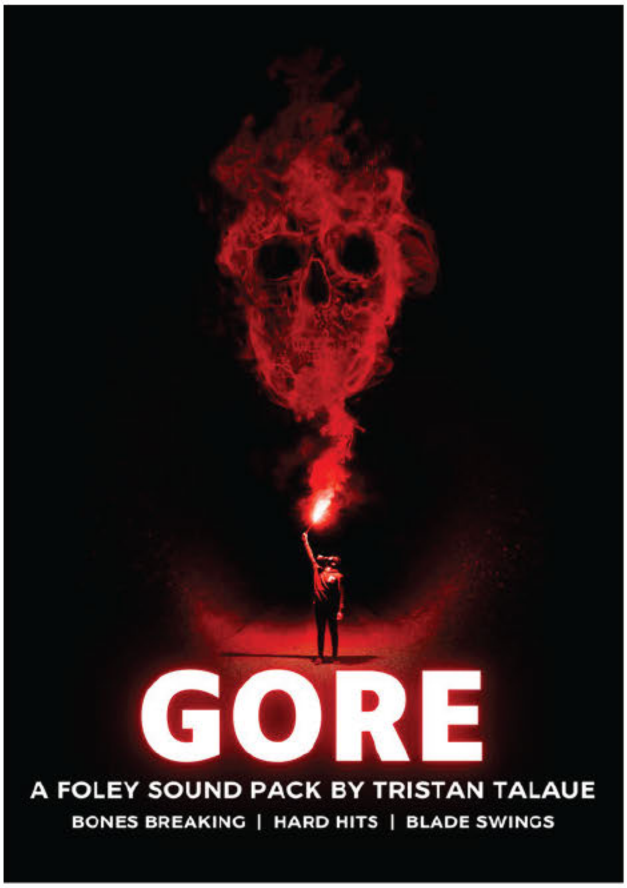
https://www.krotosaudio.com/products/foley-sound-effects-libraries-collection-vol-1/
(KROTOS)
An example Foley sample pack website where the website can be used for inspiration on how to create a website for selling my own Foley pack.

https://www.screenskills.com/job-profiles/browse/post-production/sound-studios/foley-artist-post-production/
(Screen Skills)
Explains the role of the Foley artist in the audio industry and how they can mimic on-screen actions through sound to feel natural.

https://www.backstage.com/magazine/article/how-to-create-foley-sound-effects-75583/
(Woltmann, 2022)
A quick cover on how to use the imagination and how Foley artists go about creating sounds that match what is seen on screen or create sound effects that enhance what is captured in video.

4.4 - Proof of Concept Demonstration Media Asset(s)





Above are quick mock concepts to show how the pack would be organised into subfolders and categories. Waveforms will be correctly named based on the type of sound and its action within the file. Above right is a quick poster-like advertisement to showcase the theme of gore and names some related sounds you may find in this pack. A mock website will be made to showcase the product as a retail item online by the end of 2nd project.

5.0 - Slide Deck

Link:	CIM301 Project 1 Slide Deck.pdf

6.0 - Video Presentation

Link:	CIM301 Presntation Video.mp4

7.0 - Project Checklist

Checklist (E.g. Yes or No)	
Have you completed all sections of this project template?	☑
Have you included at least one (1) APA7 reference in your Industry Skills Analysis?	☑
For your video presentation, slide deck and any other resources, have you set the share link to “Anyone with the link” and pasted the link above?	☑
Have you included your reference list below?	☑
Have you signed the AI Use Declaration below?	☑
Have you deleted all of the italicised text/prompts throughout this document?	☑

8.0 - Reference List

- *Björgvin Benediktsson*, (N/D). *The Audio Engineering Fundamentals You Need to Know If You're a Musician or Content Creator.* https://www.audio-issues.com/recording-tips/audio-engineering-fundamentals/
- *Chuck Espinoza, (April 14th, 2023) The Biggest Challenges Facing Audio Engineers Today.* https://marketscale.com/industries/pro-av/the-biggest-challenges-facing-audio-engineers-today/
- *Cole Gereb, (April 11th, 2024) Emerging Trends in Sound Design for 2024.* https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/emerging-trends-sound-design-2024-cole-gereb-vw2hc/
- *In The Know, (March 7th, 2023) The Future of Audio Engineering: Trends and Innovations in the Industry.* https://www.mi.edu/in-the-know/future-audio-engineering-trends-innovations-industry/#:~:text=Artificial%20intelligence%20and%20machine%20learning,creative%20aspects%20of%20the%20process
- *Krotos Audio, (N/D). Foley Sound Effects Libraries Collection Vol. 1* https://www.krotosaudio.com/products/foley-sound-effects-libraries-collection-vol-1/
- *Practical Music Production, (N/D). Skills Needed To Be An Audio Engineer | Expert Tips.* https://www.practical-music-production.com/skills-needed-to-be-an-audio-engineer/
- *Sandra Henke, (N/D). 13 ways to transition from student life to working life.* https://social.hays.com/2020/01/29/transition-student-life-to-working-life/
- *Screen Skills, (N/D). Foley Artist.* https://www.screenskills.com/job-profiles/browse/post-production/sound-studios/foley-artist-post-production/
- *Suzy Woltmann, (October 4th, 2022). How to Create Foley Sound Effects.* https://www.backstage.com/magazine/article/how-to-create-foley-sound-effects-75583/
- *Teal HQ, (N/D) Top Skills for Audio Engineers in 2024 (+Most Underrated Skills).* https://www.tealhq.com/skills/audio-engineer

9.0 - AI Use Declaration

I hereby confirm that I have not used generative AI in the completion of this project.

Signature:

[redacted]